A Quickstart Guide to Copyediting for the English Student

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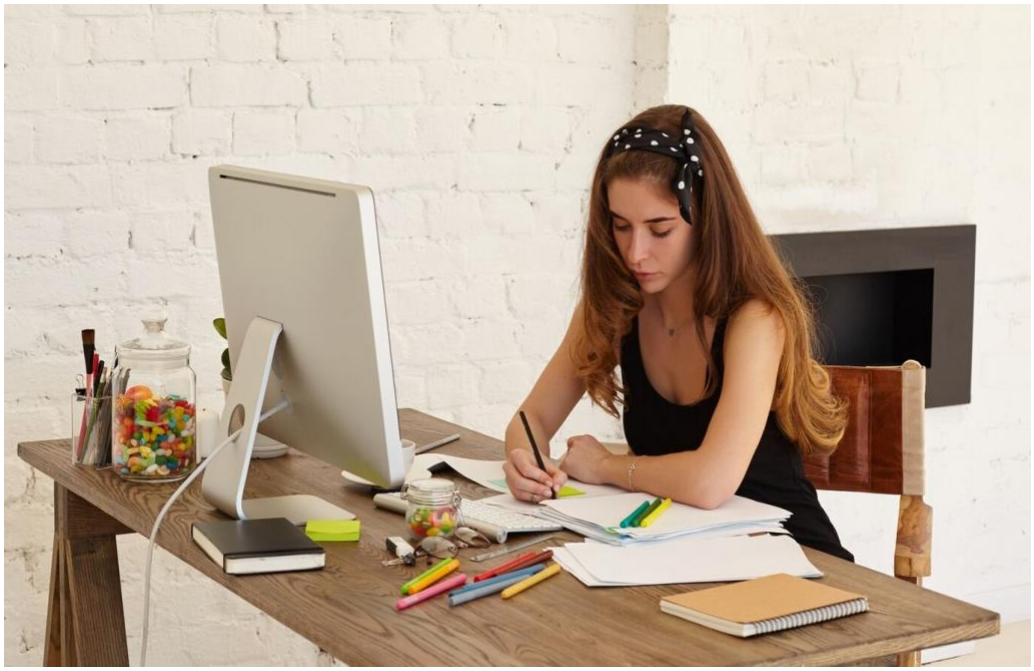
A One-Knows-All Guide

It may come as no surprise to English students that copyediting provides a great starting point into the vast, expansive world of industry writing. It utilizes all those lessons you've learned from Basic English Composition to Poetry for Romantics to Advanced Topics in Technical Writing. Furthermore, the writing skills you've practiced are applicable to every job that involves communication, whether that be drafting, revising, or speaking. For those who want to learn more about the specifics of copyediting as a job, look no further than *The Subversive Copy Editor*.

Carol Fisher Saller's book *The Subversive Copy Editor* acts as a streamlined how-to guide on entering the copyediting field, including all the do's and don't-do's. Now retired, Saller worked as a senior manuscript editor at the University of Chicago Press. In this book, she reflects on her experience answering *The Chicago Manual of Style Online's* "Chicago Style Q&A", drawing on her expertise to teach the reader everything about copy editing from freelance work to negotiating with a text word by word.



Skills for Entering the Workforce

The Subversive Copy Editor is especially useful to English students aiming to sharpen their skills before going on a job hunt. Editing is everywhere -- in articles, restaurant reviews, and art exhibits. Likewise, editing *will* be a requirement at your next writing job, even if you aren't looking to land an editing position. Saller says, "In the routines of almost any office job, a worker is likely to be responsible for a chunk of writing, and in any chunk of writing there is likely to be a problem. Solving problems

with writing is what copyediting is." For the ambitious English student, this advice could not be more useful.

Saller also provides a reasonable job description of what exactly a copy editor does in their day-to-day routine. She says, "Copy editors have a million things to do. Either we handle several overlapping projects or we handle multiple tasks within a single project." She details the techniques she uses to fully utilize a work day, such as drafting to-do lists and organizing documents. Additionally, she emphasizes the importance of balance in a copy editor's life, writing on how to confront stress in the job, identify problems, and enjoy life outside of work. "Put briefly, the way to bring your best to any job is to have a life away from the job." Landing the job is crucial, but surviving it is perhaps even more so, and Saller expertly navigates the common problems and solutions of copyediting.

Practical for Years

An up-and-coming English student eager to get their hands on a job should be willing to accept any advice they're given, and *The Subversive Copy Editor* offers lessons in an efficient, guided manner that will guarantee itself a place on the shelf through the start of a young writer's (or editor's) career. Students or recent graduates can apply the skills from Saller's book to communication in any industry, but particularly these writing positions:

- Writer
- Editor
- Tutoring
- Administrator
- Journalist
- Communication
- Librarian
- Lawyer

Remember, any advice is good advice. With *The Subversive Copy Editor* in your back pocket, you're sure to bring a touch of professionalism with you, no matter what job you end up with.